

ML FROM PRIMITIVES

2026 EDITION

ML Interview Workbook

A compact, printable workbook for ML interview preparation.

Use this to prepare for the interview you actually have. Write down the loop, choose the most important gap, attempt it closed-book, record what happened, and schedule the next attempt. The workbook covers planning, practice, simulations, stories, and the final week.

Candidate: _____

Loop date: _____

How to use it

1. **Start with recent practice.** Record confirmed rounds, time available, and what you can do without notes.
2. **Choose three gaps.** Work on the areas most likely to affect your actual loop.
3. **Attempt, compare, retry.** Keep notes closed until the attempt ends; compare your answer with the criteria; schedule the next attempt.
4. **Call a skill ready carefully.** Look for two successful attempts on different days and one unfamiliar follow-up.

1. Loop snapshot

Target role: _____

Level: _____

Primary domain: _____

Weeks available: _____

Hours per week: _____

Interview date: _____

Confirmed round formats

- ☐ ML breadth / fundamentals
- ☐ Modeling / experimentation
- ☐ LLM systems / inference
- ☐ Behavioral / leadership
- ☐ Coding / implementation

- ☐ ML system design
- ☐ Training / debugging
- ☐ Project deep-dive
- ☐ Research / work sample
- ☐ Other: _____

2. Evidence scorecard

Score only recent timed, closed-book practice. **0** means not attempted; **3** means you can give a workable timed answer; **5** means two successful attempts on different days plus an unfamiliar follow-up.

Area	0	1	2	3	4	5 / note
Fundamentals	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Production / systems	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
LLM systems	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Retrieval / search	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
System design	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Experimentation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Behavioral / leadership	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Math / research	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____
Coding / implementation	☐	☐	☐	☐	☐	_____

3. First three practice priorities

Choose gaps by importance and evidence. Each plan item should name an action, not just a topic.

01 Gap / round: _____
 Closed-book action: _____
 What success looks like: _____
 Retry date: _____

02 Gap / round: _____
 Closed-book action: _____
 What success looks like: _____
 Retry date: _____

03 Gap / round: _____
 Closed-book action: _____
 What success looks like: _____
 Retry date: _____

4. Story bank prompts

For each story, keep the ownership and evidence explicit. **Problem / stakes**

My decision

Alternatives rejected

Evidence / result

Failure or surprise

What I would change

5. Weekly operating loop

extbfMonday	Pick the three most important gaps. Name the round and what success looks like.
extbfTuesday to Thursday	Attempt closed-book. Use a visual lesson only after the attempt. Record what you could not explain, derive, design, or code.
extbfFriday	Retry one weak item and one unfamiliar transfer. Ask one follow-up that changes an assumption.
Weekend	Review the evidence, update the plan, and remove work that is no longer relevant.

This week's focus

What changed after an attempt?

Next action

6. Readiness check

Do not call a critical gap ready based on confidence alone.

- Two successful closed-book attempts on different days.
- No critical scoring area remains weak.
- One unfamiliar follow-up or changed assumption goes well.
- One later mixed practice session remains workable.
- A peer, mentor, or interviewer has challenged at least one claim when possible.

What I still need to show:



7. Closed-book attempt and retry log

Use one row per meaningful attempt. Record what you could do without notes and what changed after feedback.

Date	Round	Prompt or task	Score	Gap	Retry

Retry protocol

Before the attempt	What must I do without notes? _____
After the attempt	What could I not do yet? _____
Next practice	What is the smallest task that addresses that gap? _____
Evidence	What should improve next time? _____

8. Simulation review

Use this after a role-specific simulation or a full practice round. Separate a smooth answer from evidence that holds when an assumption changes. **Simulation / role:** _____ **Date:** _____

Rounds included: _____

Time limit and conditions: _____

What held under pressure? _____

Where did I lose structure? _____

Which assumption changed the answer? _____

What evidence was missing? _____

What will I practice before the next simulation? _____

Observer / interviewer feedback

Strongest signal

Most important improvement

Follow-up I should rehearse

9. Project and story practice

Keep the story focused on decisions, ownership, evidence, failure, and what you changed. Do not memorize a script.

90-second opening Problem, ownership, outcome, and the three decisions I will explain.

Decision 1 Constraint: _____

Choice and evidence:

Decision 2 Constraint: _____

Choice and evidence:

Decision 3 Constraint: _____

Choice and evidence:

Ownership What did I personally decide, build, unblock, or change?

Failure / surprise What failed, and how did it update the plan?

Impact and guardrail What changed for users or the business, and what could have regressed?

Changed-assumption follow-ups

01. If the data, latency, budget, or label changes:

02. If the first approach fails:

03. If a senior partner disagrees:

10. Other interview rounds

Use this page for formats outside the guide. Those formats need their own practice plan.

External format	Separate resource or drill	Baseline date
General algorithms / DSA	_____	
Practical software / OOP / concurrency	_____	
SQL / data manipulation	_____	
General distributed systems	_____	
Other:	_____	

11. Final week

The final week is for steady practice on known gaps, not broad new coverage.

- ☐ Recheck each critical round with one closed-book baseline.
- ☐ Retry only the most important weak areas.
- ☐ Run one mixed simulation with an unfamiliar follow-up.
- ☐ Practice the 90-second project opening and three decisions.
- ☐ Confirm time zone, links, format, environment, and permitted tools.
- ☐ Prepare concise questions about scope, success, collaboration, and the first 90 days.
- ☐ Stop adding broad topics; protect sleep and response quality.

Logistics / questions / risks



12. Review and backup

At the end of each week, update the plan from what you practiced, not from how you felt.

What did I complete?

What remains critical?

What should I remove or defer?

What is next week's one priority?

Backup reminder

The browser workbook is local to the device. Export its JSON backup before changing devices or clearing browser data. This printable PDF contains no private plan data.

A compact operating rule

Practice without notes. Compare your answer with the criteria. Work on one gap. Retry after time has passed. Study a topic only when it changes what you can do in the interview.